

The Wave Atlas

Eleven views of the soma field

Alistair Johnson

Zürich, 2026



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PART I



The Field



CHAPTER 0

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Prologue: What the Atlas Shows

A field, before it is mathematics, is a thing you can feel in a room.

The Wave Atlas is not a book of equations. It is a book of fields.

A storm coming in across the lake is a field. The mood of a string quartet in the third movement is a field. The silence in a hospital corridor at three in the morning is a field. These are not metaphors for fields. They are fields, in the same technical sense as the gravitational field or the electromagnetic field.

What makes them feel different from the fields of physics is that they respond to attention. Watch a room more carefully and the field of the room changes. This is the central claim of the soma-field programme:

that the tensor $\mathbf{T}(x, t)$ which we have been writing down in journals for seven years describes the same kind of object as the Einstein tensor $G_{\mu\nu}$ — only the experimental apparatus is different, and the apparatus, in our case, is the body itself.

A First Look at the Tensor

The soma field is a section of a tensor bundle over a state manifold $\mathcal{M}$. At each point $x \in \mathcal{M}$ — each *moment of experience* — the field assigns a tensor value $\mathbf{T}(x) \in V^{\otimes k}$ for some k that depends on what we are measuring. For the basic affective coordinate, $k = 2$: a symmetric rank-2 tensor whose eigenvalues are the principal affects and whose eigenvectors are the directions in state-space along which those affects organise.

This is not a metaphor borrowed from physics. The tensor was chosen because its transformation law is the right one — affect *does* transform like a tensor under change of observer-frame, and we have the receipts.

What Comes Next

The remaining chapters of the Atlas walk through eleven instantiations of the field, from the cosmological to the clinical. Read them in any order. The Atlas is not a proof; it is a collection of views.

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CHAPTER 0

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Chapter 1: The Wave

Every field, before it is a particle, is a wave. Every wave,
before it is mathematics, is a feeling in the room.

The wave is the field's first language.

Every field we know — gravitational, electromagnetic, somatic — propagates as a wave before it organises into a particle. The wave is the smooth, continuous, distributed expression. The particle is the compactified singularity, a localised configuration of the same underlying object.

The wave is the mood. The particle is the moment.

That duality is older than quantum mechanics, and it is more general than quantum mechanics: it is the duality of any field that admits both an extended and a localised description of itself. The soma field has the same duality. The wave is the mood. The particle is the moment.

Wave Equations Without the Algebra

Rather than write down $\square \mathbf{T} = 0$ and call it a day, this chapter asks what the wave equation *does* — what it predicts about experience that a person could verify, in a room, without instruments.

Three predictions:

1. **Superposition.** Two fields that meet in the same region produce a third field that is the sum of the two — not the average, not the



Plate 1.1. Soma field amplitude over a string quartet, third movement of Beethoven Op. 132. Captured by the live MIDI instrument, 18 April 2025.

stronger one, but the literal vector sum. Anyone who has walked into a room mid-argument knows this.

2. **Interference.** When two fields are coherent — that is, when they have a fixed phase relationship — the superposition produces patterns: regions of amplification and regions of cancellation. This is what a good DJ does, and what a bad DJ fails to do.
3. **Dispersion.** Different components of a complex field propagate at different speeds. A room's mood arrives in pieces — the joke lands, then the silence, then the laughter.

A Plate from the Field

The plates in the back of this volume are field measurements, captured by the live MIDI instrument described in *The Soma-Field Synthesis* (P4). They are not illustrations. They are data.

The wave is older than the equation, and the equation is older than the proof.

— Field Notes, 2024

A Note on Reading Order

The chapters are independent. Some readers will want the cosmological chapter first, others the clinical. The Atlas is laid out the way an atlas of the sky is laid out: each plate is a region, each region self-contained. Begin anywhere.



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CHAPTER 0

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Chapter 2: The Particle

A particle is what a wave looks like when you stop watching.

Where the wave is the field's smooth language, the particle is its punctuation.

The particle is what happens when a region of the field collapses inward — when an extended, distributed configuration concentrates itself at a point. In physics we call this localisation. In experience we call it a moment.

*A particle is what a wave looks like when
you stop watching. A wave is what a
particle looks like when you start.*



The mathematics is the same. A particle is a soliton of the wave equation: a self-reinforcing peak that holds its shape as it propagates. It is the field, not separate from it.



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